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The Necessities for Effective Prayer

Mark 11:22–25

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Question in View

Why does Jesus interrupt Passion Week — days before the cross — to teach on prayer, and what does He say prayer requires to be effective?

Short Answer

The disciples are about to lose the physical presence of the One who supplied their every need for three years. Jesus uses the withered fig tree to teach them how to draw on divine power when He is gone: **all of heaven's resources are at the disposal of the believer who prays**. The passage yields five necessities of effective prayer — remember (historical), trust (theological), believe (spiritual), ask (practical), and forgive (moral).

Text & Context

The setting. It is Wednesday of Passion Week. Jesus entered Jerusalem Monday; on Tuesday He cursed the fig tree on the way into the city (Mark 11:12–14) and cleansed the temple. Thursday is Passover, Friday the crucifixion, Sunday the resurrection.

The fig tree (vv. 20–21). Returning Wednesday morning, the disciples find the tree "withered from the roots up." Matthew 21:19 says it died instantly; they simply hadn't seen it in the dark the night before. The fig tree is a symbol of Israel — leaves but no fruit, profession without reality. Its cursing is an acted parable of the judgment coming on the temple, apostate Judaism, and the unbelieving nation (fulfilled A.D. 70; cf. Mark 13:2). It is the only *destructive* miracle in the Gospels — yet still a display of divine power.

The hinge. Peter marvels: "Rabbi, look, the fig tree which You cursed has withered" (v. 21). Matthew's parallel adds his question: "How did the fig tree immediately wither away?" (Matt 21:20). Jesus' answer — "Have faith in God" — is the answer to *how that kind of power works*: such power, whether for judgment or blessing, comes from God, and it is drawn down by believing prayer.

Why this lesson now. For three years the disciples' prayer lives had atrophied — why petition heaven when you could grab Jesus by the arm? They are about to become what every believer since has been: totally dependent on One they cannot see.

"Have faith in God. Truly I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, 'Be taken up and cast into the sea,' and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that what he says is going to happen, it will be granted him. Therefore I say to you, all things for which you pray and ask, believe that you have received them, and they will be granted you. Whenever you stand praying,

forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father who is in heaven will also forgive you your transgressions." — Mark 11:22–25

Textual note on v. 26. Verse 26 does not appear in the earliest manuscripts and is bracketed in most modern Bibles — likely imported by a later scribe from Matthew 6:15. Doctrine loses nothing: Matthew 6:14–15 says it explicitly.

The Original Words

ἔχετε πίστιν θεοῦ (*echete pistin theou*, "have faith in God," v. 22) — objective genitive: faith directed at God, not "God's kind of faith" (a Word-of-Faith misreading with no grammatical support). The stress falls on the object — the character of God, not the quality of your believing. *Payoff: the command is "trust God," not "generate faith."*

πιστεύω (*pisteuō*, "believe," vv. 23–24) — the operative verb. In v. 24 Jesus says "believe that you have received (*elabete*, aorist) them" — a past tense for a future answer, settled confidence that treats the answer as certain because the Giver is certain. *Payoff: faith is the empty hand that receives God's power — it has no power of its own.*

διακρίνω (*diakrinō*, "doubt," v. 23; cf. James 1:6) — to be divided, to waver between two judgments. The doubt in view is not doubting yourself — it is being double-minded about God: His power, goodness, and wisdom. *Payoff: the enemy of effective prayer is a divided verdict on God's character.*

ἀφίημι (*aphiēmi*, "forgive," v. 25) — literally to send away, hurl away, release. *Payoff: forgiveness is a decisive act of release, available instantly — which is why it can be a precondition of every prayer rather than a long project.*

The Five Necessities

1. Historical — REMEMBER (implied, vv. 20–21)

Peter's "the fig tree which You cursed has withered" is an act of remembering a display of divine power — and that is where effective prayer begins. Why call on God now if He has not proven Himself in the past?

- Deuteronomy commands "you shall remember" some fifteen times as Israel enters the land: the Exodus, the Passover, the Red Sea, manna, water from the rock.
- Isaiah 46:9 — "Remember the former things... I am God, and there is no other... declaring the end from the beginning."
- Psalms 77, 78, 105, 143 — reciting God's deeds is fuel for both worship and petition.

The more you have to remember — biblically, in church history, and personally — the stronger the foundation of your confidence. Keep the record.

2. Theological — TRUST GOD (v. 22)

"Have faith **in God**." The point is not faith; it is God. Trust His power — but also His purpose, promise, plans, and will.

- The Disciples' Prayer sets the order: "Hallowed be Your name, Your kingdom come, Your will be done" (Matt 6:9–10) — God's honor before any petition.
- 1 John 5:14–15 — "If we ask anything **according to His will**, He hears us."
- James 4:3 — asking fails when we "ask to consume it on our own desires"; James 4:15 — "If the Lord wills, we will do this or that."
- John 14:13–14 — "in My name" = consistent with His person, purpose, and will, not a verbal formula.
- Models: Paul "trusting in the Lord" from prison (Phil 1:12–14); "entrust their souls to a faithful Creator" (1 Pet 4:19).

Prayer is not cornering God. It is submission: "I want what He knows is right and true and good and best."

3. Spiritual — BELIEVE (v. 23)

- **The mountain is hyperbole**, a stock rabbinic figure — the Talmud calls great problem-solvers "rooters up of mountains." It means humanly impossible difficulties.
- **The doubt to avoid is doubting God, not doubting yourself.** The Word-of-Faith movement inverts this. Your words and your faith have zero power. God has all the power; faith only activates it within the framework of His purpose (James 1:6–8).
- **Little faith is enough.** Peter walks on water with "little faith" (Matt 14:29–31) — his "Lord, save me!" is still answered. The boy's father prevails with "I do believe; help my unbelief" (Mark 9:24). The threshold is a mustard seed (Matt 17:20).

Real faith is always mixed with some doubt this side of glory. Struggling faith still draws down the power of God.

4. Practical — ASK (v. 24)

"All things for which you pray and ask, believe that you have received them, and they will be granted you."

- James 4:2 — "You do not have because you do not ask."
- Matt 7:7–11 — "Ask and it will be given... how much more will your Father who is in heaven give what is good to those who ask Him?"
- "All things" is magnanimous but never unqualified: according to His will (1 John 5:14), not to consume on your desires (James 4:3), abiding in Him with His words abiding in you (John 15:7 — if His words shape you, He controls your wish list), in His name (John 14:13–14; 15:16; 16:23–24).
- **The model: Gethsemane.** "Abba, Father, all things are possible for You; remove this cup from Me; yet not what I will, but what You will" (Mark 14:36). Pour out the whole heart — then close with "nevertheless, not my will but Yours."

5. Moral — FORGIVE (v. 25)

"Whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone..."

- "If I regard wickedness in my heart, the Lord will not hear" (Ps 66:18). Jesus gives one decisive test: forgive — *aphiēmi*, hurl it away.
- This is **not judicial/salvation forgiveness** (settled at conversion — the "bath" of John 13:10) but **relational, fatherly forgiveness** — the daily foot-washing that keeps fellowship open and prayer unhindered.
- The unforgiving servant (Matt 18:23–35): one forgiven an unpayable debt cannot strangle a man over pocket change.
- Ephesians 4:32 — "forgiving each other, just as God in Christ also has forgiven you." The attitude of Stephen: "Lord, do not hold this sin against them" (Acts 7:60).

The choice is stark: hold a grudge, or have your prayers answered. Forgiveness is free to give and instant to grant — and it opens the way to heaven's power.

Did They Learn It? (Acts 1–2)

Within hours of the ascension, the disciples return to the Upper Room and "with one mind were continually devoting themselves to prayer" (Acts 1:14) — about 120 of them. The power came down at Pentecost (Acts 2); three thousand saved, then five thousand, and the pattern of Acts is set: prayer and power, prayer and power. "Pray without ceasing" (1 Thess 5:17).

Putting It Into Practice

1. **Build a memory of answered prayer.** Keep a written record. What Deuteronomy's "remember" did for Israel, a prayer journal does for you — it converts history into confidence.
2. **Audit the direction of your requests.** Are your prayers shaped like "my will, funded by God" or "Your kingdom, Your will, through me"? John 15:7 test: is the Word abiding in you deeply enough that He is editing your wish list?
3. **Stop measuring your faith; start measuring your God.** Mustard-seed faith with "help my unbelief" honesty is enough. The question is never "do I believe hard enough" but "is God able and good" — and the fig tree, the empty tomb, and Pentecost answer it.
4. **Run the forgiveness check before you pray.** Anyone you're holding something against? Hurl it away — now, unilaterally, before the next petition.

Discussion Questions

1. Why did the disciples' prayer life atrophy while Jesus was physically present, and where does the modern equivalent show up in us — what do we lean on instead of asking?
2. Jesus answers Peter's "how did the tree wither?" with "have faith in God." Trace the logic. What does that connection teach about where power in prayer actually resides?
3. Read James 1:6–8 alongside Mark 9:24 ("I believe; help my unbelief"). How can both be true? What is the difference between double-minded doubt and struggling faith?
4. "Believe that you have received them" (v. 24) — how do we hold this promise with full confidence *and* Gethsemane's "not my will but Yours" without emptying either one?
5. Verse 25 makes forgiving others a precondition of unhindered prayer. Is there a difference between forgiveness and reconciliation? What does *aphiēmi* ("hurl away") suggest forgiveness practically looks like this week?
6. From Acts 1–2: what changed in the disciples' practice after the ascension, and what would "prayer and power" look like in our church if we took Mark 11 seriously?

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From the author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting* — available on Amazon.

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